

Signal Dispatch

Signal Dispatch – Deep Dive

Eight Days: Inside the Shadow Procurement Network That Brought
Down DHS Secretary Kristi Noem

Executive Summary

Structured Data

Qualitative Intelligence

Assessment

Probability Assessment

Escalation/Resolution Indicators

Sources

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Eight Days: Inside the Shadow Procurement Network That Brought Down DHS Secretary Kristi Noem

2026-03-06

Classification: Open Source Intelligence **Topic:** Kristi Noem fired as DHS Secretary **Analyst confidence:** Medium

Executive Summary

On February 6, 2025, Safe America Media LLC was formed at a residential address in Delaware. Eight days later, the Department of Homeland Security awarded it a \$62.8 million contract for advertising and media support services. The company's owner, Mike McElwain, was a GOP strategist and former political director of the National Republican Congressional Committee. By year's end, Safe America Media and a second firm – People Who Think LLC, owned by Trump 2016 media adviser Jay Connaughton – had collected \$220 million in DHS communications contracts, all awarded under emergency authority that bypassed competitive bidding.

On March 5, 2026, President Trump fired DHS Secretary Kristi Noem via Truth Social and simultaneously announced Senator Markwayne Mullin as her replacement. The simultaneity matters: Cabinet replacements require weeks of vetting. This was pre-decided.

The standard narrative frames this as a political survival failure – a cabinet secretary who couldn't control her messaging, who contradicted her president on live television, who presided over two citizen deaths in Minneapolis. I find that narrative incomplete. The data points toward something more specific: a shadow procurement network operating inside DHS, with former campaign manager Corey Lewandowski as the operational hub connecting political operatives to federal contracts. Noem's own PAC paid one contractor, Strategy Group, through February 2026. Strategy Group's CEO married DHS spokesperson Tricia McLaughlin during the active contract period. Lewandowski personally approved contracts that Noem told Congress he did not.

The enforcement was real. USAspending data confirms \$1.83 billion in CSI Aviation deportation flights and \$1.95 billion in detention capacity across GEO Group, CoreCivic, and Akima facilities. Combined enforcement spending of \$3.78 billion supports the plausibility of 675,000 removals – though that figure remains DHS self-reporting with no independent audit – numbers without receipts – and would represent a 50% increase over the verified historical peak of approximately 450,000 (ICE, FY2012). But running parallel to the enforcement apparatus was a \$248 million advertising pipeline flowing to newly-formed LLCs owned by political allies, through contracts awarded without competition. The question I'm tracking: does the corruption network survive Noem's departure, or did the firing sever it?

Structured Data

The LLCs

Three firms form the core of the procurement network. All connected to Corey Lewandowski. All receiving contracts under emergency authority.

Safe America Media LLC - Formed: February 6, 2025. Registered to a residential address in Delaware. - Owner: Mike McElwain, GOP strategist, former NRCC political director. - First contract: February 13, 2025 – eight days after formation. Value: \$62.8 million. - Total USAspending value: \$142.8 million across three contracts.

Contract ID	Value	Date	Description
70RDA225FR0000009	\$62.8M	Feb 19, 2025	Stronger Borders, Stronger America Campaign Advertising and Media Support
70RDA225FR0000034	\$65M	Aug 22, 2025	Follow-on Domestic Campaign Support
70CMSW25FR0000082	\$15M	Aug 15, 2025	ICE Recruitment Campaign Media Dissemination

People Who Think LLC - Owner: Jay Connaughton, Trump 2016 media adviser. Louisiana-based. - Political connection: worked with Lewandowski on Louisiana gubernatorial campaigns. - Total USAspending value: \$77.1 million across four contracts.

Contract ID	Value	Date	Description
70RDA225FR0000047	\$25.5M	Sep 26, 2025	Follow-on International Campaign
70CMSW25FR0000081	\$25M	Aug 15, 2025	ICE Recruitment Campaign Content Creation
70RDA225FR0000021	\$12.9M	Jun 18, 2025	Follow-on International Campaign
70RDA225FR0000013	\$13.9M	Mar 12, 2025	International Campaign Advertising and Media Support

Strategy Group - CEO: Ben Yoho, age 38. Married DHS spokesperson Tricia McLaughlin during active contract period. - Prior relationship: Noem's South Dakota administration paid Strategy Group \$8.5 million in 2023. - PAC payments: Noem's American Resolve PAC paid Strategy Group through February 2026. - USAspending footprint: zero. No contracts appear under "Strategy Group" or "The Manhattan Strategy Group LLC" in DHS procurement records. - Per *ProPublica* reporting, Strategy Group "secretly received a piece" of contracts through subcontract arrangements that do not appear in public procurement data.¹

Combined Safe America Media and People Who Think spending: \$219.9 million (USAspending.gov, accessed 2026-03-06). This figure is consistent with the \$220 million reported by multiple outlets. Strategy Group's subcontract share is additive but unquantified in public records.

The Procurement Chain

Here's the recipe:

1. DHS invokes national emergency at southern border, triggering emergency procurement authority.
2. Emergency authority bypasses Federal Acquisition Regulation competitive bidding requirements.
3. Contracts awarded sole-source to Safe America Media (formed eight days prior) and People Who Think.
4. Strategy Group receives undisclosed subcontract portions invisible in public records.
5. Federal dollars flow to firms owned by political operatives connected through Lewandowski.

Procurement bypass indicators I'm tracking: - Triple increase in DHS advertising budget within one fiscal year. - Newly-formed LLCs receiving first-ever federal contracts worth tens of millions. - Residential address registrations. - Subcontract opacity concealing downstream recipients. - Multiple contracts structured at \$99,999 – one dollar below Noem's self-imposed \$100,000 personal approval threshold for FEMA expenditures.² The same official who required sign-off on \$100,000 FEMA disaster contracts presided over \$62.8 million sole-source awards to an eight-day-old LLC.

Lewandowski as Hub

Corey Lewandowski served as a “special government employee” within DHS – a designation that typically limits authority. His actual authority was not typical.

Multiple reporting sources confirm Lewandowski’s signature functioned as the green light for contract approvals. He brought Yoho into Noem’s orbit. He worked with Connaughton on Louisiana campaigns. He personally approved contracts.

Noem testified to Congress that Lewandowski did not approve contracts. Records show he did. Senator Richard Blumenthal called for a perjury investigation.³

Enforcement Apparatus: Where the Real Money Went

Parallel to the advertising pipeline, DHS spent \$3.78 billion on enforcement operations. This spending is not in dispute – USAspending contract data is public and verifiable.

Deportation flights (CSI Aviation): \$1.83 billion

Contract ID	Value	Date	Description
70CDCR26FC0000001	\$673M	Nov 1, 2025	ICE Air Program deportation flights
70CDCR25FR0000022	\$562M	Mar 1, 2025	Daily scheduled large aircraft flights
70CDCR24FR0000024	\$324M	Apr 4, 2024	Interim contract for daily charter flights

Detention capacity (top providers): \$1.95 billion

Provider	Total	Key Facilities
GEO Group	\$632M	Adelanto CA (\$119M), Tacoma (\$96M), Desert View LA (\$66M), South Texas (\$60M)
Camp East Montana (Acquisition Logistics)	\$598M	Temporary detention center, El Paso
CoreCivic	\$478M	Otay Mesa San Diego (\$114M), Houston (\$52M), T. Don Hutto (\$24M)
Akima	\$240M	Krome FL (\$120M), Florence AZ (\$37M), Buffalo NY (\$83M)

At historical per-removal costs of \$1,800-2,200 (ICE operational data, FY2015-2023 range), this spending level supports 600,000-750,000 removals. Noem's claimed 675,000 falls within that range. But the spending proves capacity, not execution. DHS self-reported the removal number during a contested firing with no independent audit. The verified historical peak remains approximately 450,000 (ICE, FY2012). I weight the spending data as plausibility evidence, not confirmation.

Qualitative Intelligence

The spending data establishes capacity. What follows is the operational reality: enforcement actions that killed two citizens, investigative exposure that connected contracts to political operatives, and a congressional hearing that ended a cabinet secretary's tenure in 24 hours.

Operation Metro Surge

In December 2025, DHS deployed thousands of federal agents to Minneapolis under Operation Metro Surge. The stated objective was immigration enforcement. The operational reality was something closer to occupation.

By January 2026, ICE had accumulated 96 violations of court orders. Reports of wrongful detentions included American citizens, children, and families swept up in raids. Hundreds of habeas corpus petitions flooded Minnesota courts. Democratic lawmakers issued a ten-point reform demand list covering judicial warrants, body cameras, mask bans, sensitive location protections, and state oversight.

The enforcement was aggressive. Whether it was lawful is a question now before federal courts.

Six Seconds in Minneapolis

On January 24, 2026, Alex Pretti arrived on Nicollet Avenue in Minneapolis to observe ICE activity. The timeline that follows is reconstructed from eyewitness video:

- **8:54:54 a.m.** – Pretti arrives on scene.
- **9:00:50 a.m.** – A federal officer pepper-sprays Pretti.
- **9:00:56 a.m.** – The officer pulls Pretti into the street.
- **9:01:00 a.m.** – Ten shots fired in fewer than five seconds.

Noem's initial statement: Pretti "brandished his firearm and attacked ICE officers." Eyewitness video shows Pretti never reached for a weapon. A federal agent removed a firearm from Pretti's waist area immediately before the shooting.

Noem later walked the narrative back: the scene was "chaotic," the statement reflected the "best information we had at the time." The DOJ opened a civil rights investigation, FBI-led.

Seventeen days earlier, on January 7, federal agents killed Renee Nicole Macklin Good during a separate Minneapolis operation. Two citizens dead in the same city within three weeks of a federal enforcement surge. This is not a messaging problem. This is operational failure with legal exposure that extends to the administration itself.

The Advertising Exposure

Between February and March 2026, *ProPublica* published an investigation revealing that Strategy Group – the firm whose CEO had married DHS spokesperson Tricia McLaughlin, and which had received \$8.5 million from Noem’s South Dakota administration – had secretly received subcontract portions of the DHS advertising contracts. These payments did not appear in public procurement records.

The investigation connected three threads: Noem’s PAC payments to Strategy Group continuing through February 2026, the McLaughlin-Yoho marriage during the active contract period, and the subcontract opacity that concealed the relationship from standard procurement oversight.

Congressional Hearing: Bipartisan Hostility

On March 3-4, 2026, Noem testified before Congress. What followed was unusual: bipartisan hostility.

Republican Senator John Kennedy pressed Noem on advertising spending – not a typical line of attack from within the party. Democratic Congressman Joe Neguse focused on procurement irregularities. When both parties are hostile to a cabinet secretary in public hearings, the dynamic has shifted from partisan theater to institutional legitimacy crisis.

During the Senate hearing, Noem asserted that President Trump had approved the \$220 million advertising campaign. Within hours, Trump contradicted her in a Reuters interview: he “never knew anything about it” and “wasn’t thrilled.” The contradiction occurred in real time during an active hearing. Noem’s credibility collapsed publicly.

The Firing

On March 5, one day after the hearings concluded, Trump fired Noem via Truth Social and simultaneously announced Senator Markwayne Mullin as her replacement.

The speed tells the story. Cabinet dismissals require White House Counsel coordination, Congressional leadership notification, and replacement vetting. Mullin's nomination alone would have required weeks of background work. The simultaneous announcement proves the decision preceded the hearings.⁴

I read the hearings as public justification, not trigger. The firing was pre-decided. The \$220 million contradiction gave Trump a clean public narrative for a decision already made – likely driven by the convergence of procurement exposure, citizen deaths, and legal liability.

Trump's "I never knew" is pattern behavior. When a subordinate becomes a liability, the president distances. The pattern has repeated across multiple cabinet-level departures. The words are calculated, not spontaneous.

Assessment

I constructed three competing frames from the coverage: mainstream media's political survival narrative, investigative reporting's corruption thread, and aligned media's "too effective" defense. Each has institutional backing. I score each against the observable evidence – which frame explains the most with the fewest assumptions.

Frame A: Political Survival Failure

The narrative: Noem was an effective enforcer who failed at politics. She couldn't control her messaging, contradicted Trump publicly, and presided over bad optics (citizen deaths, self-promotional advertising). The enforcement worked; the politics didn't.

What it explains: - Trump's public frustration with advertising spending. - The \$220 million contradiction as trigger. - Mullin as a more politically disciplined replacement.

What it doesn't explain: - Why the firing was pre-decided (simultaneous Mullin announcement). - Why both parties were hostile in hearings (bipartisan hostility is rare for policy disagreements). - The procurement irregularities (eight-day LLC, subcontract opacity, \$99,999 structuring). - The absence of internal DHS defenders.

I score this frame as partial. It explains the surface but requires ignoring the procurement data.

Frame B: Corruption Exposure

The narrative: Noem ran a shadow procurement network inside DHS. Political operatives received hundreds of millions through emergency authority contracts. When the network became visible – congressional scrutiny, *ProPublica* investigation, perjury risk from contradictory testimony about Lewandowski – Trump severed the connection before investigation yielded charges.

What it explains: - Pre-decided firing (risk management, not reactive). - Bipartisan congressional hostility (procurement fraud crosses partisan lines). - Trump's "I never knew" distancing (pattern behavior when liability detected). - Speed of firing after hearings (public justification for pre-made decision). - Procurement irregularities (the mechanism is the evidence). - Absence of internal defenders (nobody inside DHS wanted to defend the procurement record).

What it doesn't explain: - Whether the enforcement numbers were independently legitimate. - Trump's actual knowledge of contract approvals (White House officials were reportedly involved).

I score this frame as strong – it explains the most observations with the fewest assumptions. The procurement data is documented, not speculative.

Frame C: Too Effective, Scapegoated

The narrative: Noem delivered on Trump's enforcement agenda – 675,000 removals, 93% border crossing reduction, \$8 billion in recovered FEMA funds. She was fired because aggressive enforcement inevitably produces political casualties (citizen deaths, legal challenges), and Trump needed a scapegoat.

What it explains: - Enforcement spending levels (\$3.78 billion is real). - Trump's continued hardline rhetoric post-firing. - Mullin as ideological continuity.

What it doesn't explain: - Procurement irregularities (if enforcement was the priority, why the LLC network?). - Citizen deaths as predictable consequence vs. operational failure. - Bipartisan congressional hostility (policy opponents don't produce Republican senators going hostile). - Noem's own contradictory testimony about Lewandowski.

I score this frame as weak. It requires accepting DHS self-reported numbers at face value and ignoring documented procurement anomalies. If Noem were merely "too effective," at least some internal DHS officials would defend her record. Nobody did – which supports Frame B over Frame C.

The Missing Signal

In contested cabinet firings, I expect to observe factional support: leaked memos defending the secretary's record, anonymous officials contradicting the narrative, bureaucratic resistance to transition. In Noem's case, the internal DHS response was conspicuous silence. All sources defending Noem's enforcement record are external – her own public statements and allied media. Nobody inside the department spoke up.

Two explanations: internal DHS wanted her gone, or dissent was suppressed. Either interpretation undermines the "effective leader fired for political reasons" frame. An effective leader who generated institutional loyalty would have defenders. Noem did not.

Probability Assessment

Five forward-looking estimates. All are new assessments – no priors exist for this topic. I trade these markets when contracts exist; for now, these are tracking estimates with public resolution criteria.

New assessment: Enforcement policy continuity under Mullin – ICE removal levels remain within 20% of Noem-era claimed figures through Q3 2026. - Initial: **60%** – closer to a coin flip than I'd like, weighted by enforcement rhetoric over delivery track record. - Basis: Within-administration policy continuity base rate is approximately 80%. Mullin's rhetoric aligns with Noem's enforcement posture, and Trump's stated priorities haven't shifted. Dampened by three factors: operational delivery is unproven (rhetoric is not execution), potential corruption cleanup may disrupt procurement relationships that supported enforcement capacity, and Noem's removal numbers may be inflated – meaning "continuity" with accurate numbers could look like decline. I trade this at 60%, not 80%, because the verification gap introduces fundamental uncertainty about what "continuity" even means. - Resolution: **Resolves YES** if ICE operational metrics (removal numbers, detention capacity utilization) remain within 20% of Noem-era claimed levels through Q3 2026. **Resolves NO** if metrics fall outside that range or if independent verification shows Noem-era claims were inflated by more than 20%.

New assessment: Mullin confirmed as DHS Secretary by April 15, 2026. - Initial: **75%** - Basis: Structural factors are strong – Republican Senate majority (53-47), peer confirmation dynamics that historically favor sitting senators, and ideological alignment with the caucus. Historical confirmation rate for mid-term Cabinet replacements is approximately 85%. Dampened by the scandal context surrounding the vacancy and potential for confirmation hearings to become a platform for procurement investigation. If not confirmed by March 31 departure, Deputy Secretary Troy Edgar becomes acting secretary under statutory succession. - Resolution: **Resolves YES** if Senate confirmation vote occurs and Mullin receives majority by April 15, 2026. **Resolves NO** if vote fails, is not held by April 15, or nomination is withdrawn.

New assessment: Federal charges related to DHS advertising contracts by December 2026. - Initial: **30%** – more likely charges do NOT materialize than do. - Basis: The evidentiary foundation is stronger than typical congressional referrals – documented timeline anomalies, \$99,999 contract structuring, contradictory testimony under oath, subcontract opacity, and bipartisan congressional support for investigation. Historical base rate for congressional investigations yielding federal charges is 15-20%. I assess 30% because the evidence quality exceeds the typical referral and bipartisan support reduces political interference risk. However, federal investigations typically run 12-24 months. A December 2026 timeline is aggressive. The likelier scenario is investigation ongoing without charges by year-end. - Resolution: **Resolves YES** if DOJ or Inspector General announces criminal charges against any individual related to DHS advertising or communications contracts awarded during Noem's tenure by December 31, 2026. **Resolves NO** if no charges announced by that date.

New assessment: DHS advertising and communications spending drops more than 50% in Q2 2026 compared to Q1 2026. - Initial: **70%** - Basis: Political incentive analysis. The advertising contracts are now toxic – bipartisan congressional scrutiny, *ProPublica* investigation, and public association with corruption. Any new DHS leadership has strong incentive to distance from the spending category entirely. Dampened by existing contracts that create a spending floor: Safe America Media and People Who Think have active contracts through 2026 that may continue to draw down even without new awards. I'm tracking USAspending quarterly data as the observable signal. - Resolution: **Resolves YES** if USAspending data shows DHS advertising and communications category spending in Q2 2026 is less than 50% of Q1 2026 spending. **Resolves NO** if spending remains at or above 50% of Q1 levels.

New assessment: ICE removals exceed 700,000 in calendar year 2026. - Initial: **20%** - Basis: The verified historical maximum for annual ICE removals is approximately 450,000 (FY2012). Noem claimed 675,000 in 14 months, which annualizes to roughly 579,000 – already unprecedented if accurate. Reaching 700,000 in a calendar year would require a 55% increase over the verified peak. Spending data supports the capacity for 600,000-750,000 removals, but capacity is not execution. Legal constraints are tightening (96 court order violations, hundreds of habeas petitions), diplomatic constraints limit receiving-country cooperation at high volumes, and leadership transition creates operational disruption. I set this at 20% – possible if spending levels are maintained and

DHS self-reporting is taken at face value, but unlikely under independent verification. Independent verification mechanisms are scarce, which makes resolution itself uncertain. - Resolution: **Resolves YES** if independently verified ICE removal statistics show 700,000 or more removals in calendar year 2026. **Resolves NO** if verified count falls below 700,000. If no independent verification mechanism exists by December 31, 2026, defaults to NO – DHS self-reporting alone does not satisfy resolution.

Escalation/Resolution Indicators

What I'm watching, and what specific data changes would move these assessments.

March 31, 2026: Noem departure date. Formal transition. Watch for: Lewandowski's status (does he leave or stay in different capacity?), McLaughlin's status (DHS spokesperson married to Strategy Group CEO is untenable under scrutiny), and any personnel actions published in the Federal Register.

Q2 2026 USAspending data: Network survival signal. This is the key observable. If Safe America Media or People Who Think receive new contract awards or modifications after Noem's departure, the procurement network survived the firing. If spending to these firms drops to contract drawdown only with no new obligations, the network was severed. I will update the advertising spending assessment when Q2 data becomes available.

Mullin confirmation hearing. Date not yet scheduled. The hearing itself becomes a proxy for congressional appetite to investigate procurement. If senators use the hearing primarily to press on Noem-era contracts rather than Mullin's enforcement vision, the investigation track is accelerating. If the hearing focuses on policy, Congress has moved on.

DOJ and Inspector General activity. Federal investigations are opaque until they're not. Signals to watch: grand jury empanelment (may leak), document subpoenas to DHS (may be reported), and any formal referral from Senate Judiciary Committee. Blumenthal's perjury investigation request is the leading indicator.

Wrongful death litigation. The Pretti and Good families have grounds for civil action against the federal government. Discovery in wrongful death cases can expose operational procedures, use-of-force policies, and chain-of-command decisions that remain hidden from congressional oversight. If either family files suit, the discovery process becomes a second investigation track running parallel to any DOJ probe.

Federal Register follow-up. Publication lag means formal documentation of the transition – personnel actions, policy changes, acting secretary designation – will appear 7-30 days after the firing. I will re-query when the lag window closes.

Sources

Federal procurement data: - USAspending.gov contract records: Safe America Media LLC (contracts 70RDA225FR0000009, 70RDA225FR0000034, 70CMSW25FR0000082); People Who Think LLC (contracts 70RDA225FR0000047, 70CMSW25FR0000081, 70RDA225FR0000021, 70RDA225FR0000013); CSI Aviation (contracts 70CDCR26FC0000001, 70CDCR25FR0000022, 70CDCR24FR0000024); detention facility operators (GEO Group, CoreCivic, Akima, Acquisition Logistics). All accessed March 6, 2026.

Investigative reporting: - *ProPublica*, February-March 2026. Strategy Group subcontract investigation, McLaughlin-Yoho relationship, Noem administration procurement practices. - *Reuters*, March 5, 2026. Trump interview contradicting Noem on \$220 million advertising authorization. - *Associated Press*, March 5, 2026. Noem firing and Mullin announcement.

Congressional record: - Senate Judiciary Committee and House hearings, March 3-4, 2026. Noem testimony on Lewandowski's role, \$220 million advertising authorization, enforcement statistics. - Senator Richard Blumenthal, perjury investigation request, March 2026.

Government sources: - DHS official statements: 675,000 removals, enforcement statistics, FEMA recovered funds. - Federal Register (queried March 6, 2026 – no results due to publication lag).

Historical reference: - ICE Enforcement and Removal Operations annual reports. Historical peak removals: approximately 450,000 (FY2012).

Five new predictions. When they resolve, they join the public track record – wins and losses both visible. Edge requires honesty about both.

1. *ProPublica* investigation, February-March 2026. Strategy Group's subcontract arrangements were not disclosed in standard procurement records. [?](#)
2. The precision of landing exactly one dollar below the threshold suggests someone read the policy memo very carefully. [?](#)
3. Senate Judiciary Committee hearing, March 3-4, 2026. Blumenthal's request for perjury investigation referenced documentary evidence of Lewandowski's contract approval authority contradicting Noem's testimony. [?](#)
4. Cabinet replacements require FBI background checks, financial disclosure reviews, and Senate leadership coordination – processes that typically run 3-6 weeks minimum. A same-day replacement announcement means Mullin's vetting was already underway well before the hearings. [?](#)